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Inter Kashi's **rise to the ISL** reflects the potential of India's domestic football structure, even as the club awaits its first competitive outing in its home city of Varanasi.

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On a pleasant February morning, away from the urban cacophony and dust, silence fractured gently — first with bursts of laughter and then the rhythmic thud of leather on natural grass.

The I-League champion Inter Kashi (**above**) was training at FC Madras in Mahabalipuram, Chennai. The team had won a pre-season friendly against Chennaiyin FC the previous day, but there was no room for complacency.

Coach Antonio Lopez Habas, a hard taskmaster, stood watching. At times, the 68-year-old discussed player movements with assistant Carlos Fonseca and shook his head at every miss.

In a country where the men's football pyramid had stood frozen for seven months, Habas knew time was invaluable and preparation the ultimate currency.

Kashi joined the I-League — the second division of men's football in India — through corporate entry in 2023 and secured

promotion to the Indian Super League (ISL) within two seasons.

"When I joined the club around November 2023, it was just a few months old, and we were trying to make a mark. I clearly felt that the only thing that gives you visibility is the trophy," Prithijit Das, president and CEO of Inter Kashi, told *Sportstar*.

Prithijit was one of the architects of Atletico de Kolkata, the inaugural ISL champion in 2014, and he roped in ISL veterans Arindam Bhattacharya (champion with ATK) and Peter Hartley (Shield winner with Jamshedpur FC) at Kashi.

Inter Kashi finished an impressive fourth in its maiden season, three